

**The Toshiba M30 matches the Apple notebooks when it comes to aesthetic appeal. It promises great performance too**

or parallel. All models had at least two USB ports and one Firewire port.

All notebooks offer Wi-Fi access via 802.11b adapters. Only the Compaq X1237AP provided Bluetooth. All the notebooks provide an Ethernet port and inbuilt modem. The Compaq X1237AP, the Toshiba Satellite M30, the LG LM40, and the LG LM50, provided an SD card reader, while Samsung's X10 and P30 offer Memory Stick, and SD/MMC support.

An ATi Mobility Radeon 9200 graphics powers Compaq's X1237AP and the LG LM40, while the LG LM 50 offered the better performing Mobility Radeon 9600. Samsung had GeForce 440 Go and Geforce FX-5200 Go for their X10 and P30 models respectively. The rest used Intel's Extreme Graphics 2 for their display requirements. The Radeon-powered notebooks offer better graphics performance as compared to the Intel chipset-powered notebook.

Except for Compaq's X1237AP, which had a DVD-Writer, the rest came with Combo drives to write CDs and read DVDs. Windows XP Professional was the chosen OS for most of these laptops, but Compaq, Toshiba and Samsung X05 offer the Home edition. Compaq was the only vendor to bundle a carry case.

### Usability

Samsung X10 and X05 were the only notebooks in this category to weigh below 2 kg. Unmatched in their portability, these two notebooks should be on your list if you are looking for a slim notebook.

LG's LM 40 weighs over 2 kgs, and is as slim as the two Samsungs. Toshiba's satellite M30 and Compaq's X1237Ap are the heaviest at 3 kgs, due to their 15.4-inch wide screens. All the other notebooks weigh in at between 2.3 and 2.7 kgs.

Ergonomically, Samsung and Toshiba win hands down with the perfect placement of keys, and superb touchpad implementation—especially the Samsung models. The Compaq X1237AP model is a delight to use, but its touchpad spoils the experience somewhat. All the LG models are decent, nothing extraordinary.



LG LM50



Compaq X1237AP



Toshiba M30

### How To Buy A Good Laptop Bag

A leather bag that carries the laptop and protects it from jerks and scratches is a useful accessory. Here is what you need to look out for while buying one:

☐ Choose a top-loading bag whose zip can be drawn halfway through. This might make it a bit tedious to pull the laptop out, but it reduces the chances of it falling accidentally—which is what happens often with standard cases.

☐ The bag should have cushioned pads at the bottom as well on its sides. Without them, the chances of damage are higher as leather cannot bear that much weight for long.

☐ Make sure the bag has pockets for PCMCIA cards, CDs, business cards and pens.

Compaq and Toshiba notebooks are covered by a 1 year carry-in warranty, and claim turn-around times of 24 hours. LG and Samsung provide 3 years of carry-in warranty. Samsung products are covered by a replacement warranty, and the claimed turn-around-time is 48 hours; LG claims 24 hours for its notebooks.

### Performance

LG's LM 50 topped the PC Mark 2004 results, displacing Samsung's P30 and the Compaq X1237AP to second and third position respectively. The PC Mark results tell us that the LG LM50 provides the best overall performance.

In the system benchmarking test, Samsung's X10 posted the highest score, thanks to advantage of an extra 256 MB of RAM. The next best scores were posted by the Toshiba M30 and the LG LM 40.

The video encoding test saw the LG LM 50 churn out the maximum frames per minute, followed by Compaq's X1237AP and the Toshiba M30.

On the gaming front, the Compaq X1237AP ruled the roost, followed closely by the Samsung P30. The others are mediocre performers, but this doesn't say much as most laptop users don't buy laptops to play games. The point is, the Samsung P30 and Compaq X1237AP have great graphics sub-systems that might come in handy.

On the wireless front, Samsung led the pack—all their models cruised through most of the tests that we put them through. The Compaqs and LGs also returned impressive performances.

Overall, LG's LM50 is the best-performing notebook, but only beating the Samsung's X10 by a small margin of just one point.

### Conclusion

Based on overall performance, features, warranty coverage and usability, LG's LM50 comes out top to clinch our Best Buy Gold award for this category. It was too hard to choose between the Toshiba Satellite M30 and Compaq X1237AP for the Best Buy Silver award, so we decided that both deserved it.

However, the cool looking Toshiba Satellite M30 garners more flaunt value than the sedate,